



clans, and each person takes the name of their clan as their last name. Over 35,000 Sherpas live in West Asia. Set high in the Himalayas, eastern Nepal has the largest Sherpa population, with over 10,000 people.

Sherpas also live in Tibet, Bhutan, and India. Within Nepal, the biggest community is in the Khumbu valley—"the gateway to Mount Everest"—where there is plenty of work in the tourist industry.

SERVING THE TOURISTS

This village shop caters to tourists, many of whom come to Nepal to see the Himalayas. The shop sells souvenirs such as Sherpa-style teapots, and practical goods like backpacks used in mountaineering. Sherpas also act as guides for mountaineers, especially on major expeditions up Mount Everest. Before climbing Everest, Sherpas perform *puja*, a ceremony honoring the mountain deities, asking for a safe return.



BUDDHISM

Sherpas are Buddhists. A small minority become monks and dedicate themselves entirely to their faith. They live in the monastery all year round, studying scriptures and praying.



These houses are built into the mountainside at a height of around 13,000 ft (4,000 m) above sea level.

